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TRAVEL // OUTDOORS

This ‘magical’ 21-mile trail on the edge of Yosemite was nearly erased by fire. It’s about to reopen

By **Gregory Thomas**, Staff Writer

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Gift Article



After being closed for the past eight years, the 21-mile South Fork Merced River Trail is on the cusp of reopening to hikers, backpackers and anglers.

Gregory Thomas / S.F. Chronicle

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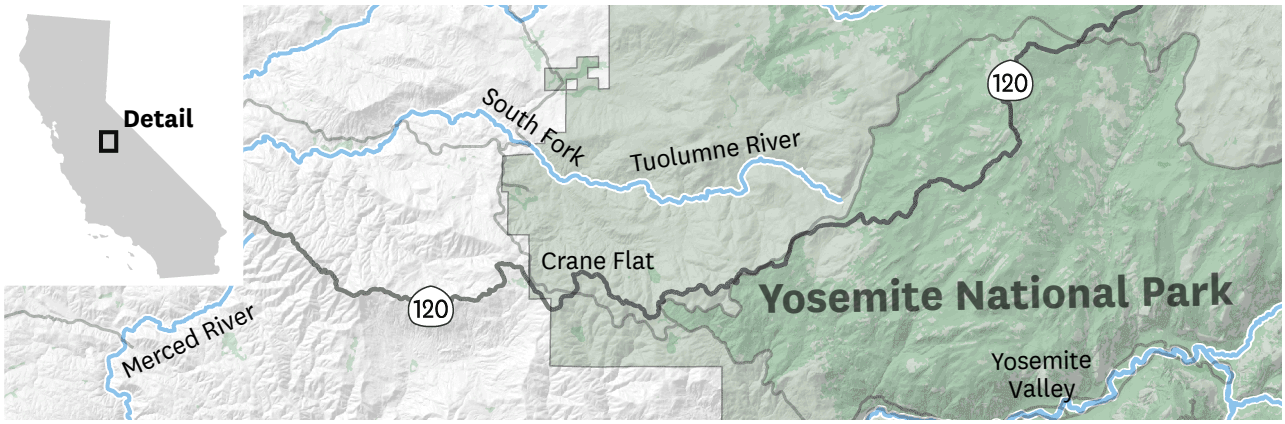
Marching through knee-high brush at the western edge of Yosemite National Park, Bill King paused by the furrowed trunk of a ponderosa pine and gazed toward the river canyon that zigzagged through the mountain folds ahead.

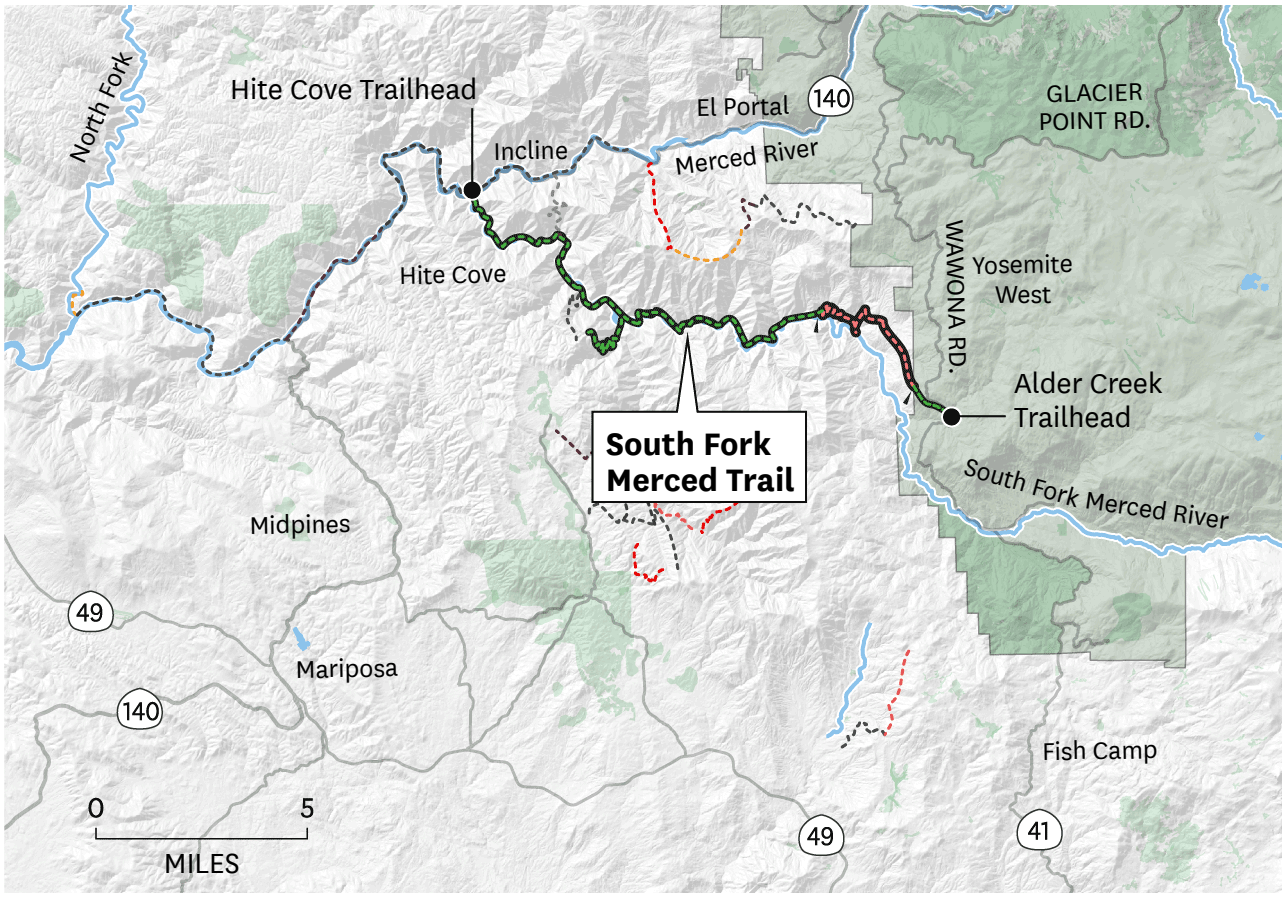
A once-glorious 21-mile thru-hiking trail along this remote section of the South Fork Merced River was destroyed by wildfire and storms eight years ago, and King, founder of the nonprofit Mariposa Trails, has been battling to resurrect it.

After years of intensive labor — sawing through hundreds of fallen trees, lopping back shrubs and digging drainage structures — a trail crew is attempting to clear the final mile this month. If all goes according to plan, the entire route will once again be passable starting in early November.

“For people who have been to Yosemite and are looking for something new — and they want a challenging trail experience — this will be a great one,” King said.

Rehabilitating the South Fork Trail, as it’s known, means restoring one of Northern California’s great, little-known thru-hikes.





Map: John Blanchard/S.F Chronicle · Source: MariposaTrails.org

The trek begins at an unmarked trailhead on Wawona Road just inside Yosemite National Park and descends first through stands of pines and fields of bear clover. About 1 mile down, as the peaks flanking the South Merced come into view, the trail crosses into Sierra National Forest, offering a pathway into a remote and seldom seen expanse of the western slopes.

The route then traces the granite and marble contours of the rugged river canyon on a northwest course all the way to the Hite Cove Trail, one of the forest’s most popular hiking areas, and out to Highway 140 a short drive from Yosemite’s Arch Rock entrance.

With several primitive trail camps stationed along the trail, it presents as an enticing destination for a two- or three-night backpacking trip — particularly during the shoulder seasons when temperatures in the canyon remain comfortable.

“It’s kind of this unknown abyss that people have been passing by in their eagerness to get to Yosemite,” said King, who lives in nearby Bootjack (Mariposa County). “It’s a great place to go if you want some peace and solitude and wilderness without crowds.”



The landscape surrounding the trail was hit hard by wildfire in 2018 but the native pines, cedars and oaks are regrowing. Gregory Thomas / S.F. Chronicle

The trail’s origin is murky, but King, who has done extensive research, suspects it was first traveled by the region’s indigenous people. Later, in the 19th century, parts of it were used by gold seekers who erected a small backcountry mining village by the river, the remnants of which were mostly destroyed by wildfire a century or more ago.

The earliest configuration of Yosemite’s park boundaries contained the entire trail, King said, before timber interests persuaded the government to peel back the park’s southwest corner for the purpose of logging valuable sugar pines on the ridges above the South Merced.

“It probably still should be part of the park,” said Beth Kellner, Mariposa Trails treasurer. “It’s a very special place.”

Eight years ago, the trail was nearly lost.

First, an enormous summertime wildfire burned through the forests near Wawona, consuming nearly 100,000 acres between El Portal and Oakhurst. Then cycles of winter rains pounded the burn area, blowing out segments of the South Fork Trail and giving rise to a dense layer of brambly shrubs impossible to hike through.



King describes himself as a fanatic for trail maintenance and has made an estimated 60 trips to repair the South Fork Merced River Trail.

Gregory Thomas / S.F. Chronicle

“I realized, if we don’t get this trail open, it’ll completely vanish,” King said. “That’s when we really got to work.”

In 2022, King’s group secured a five-year, $360,000 grant from the Sierra Nevada Conservancy to restore the trail. Michael Pickard, an area representative for the conservancy, said the project will benefit the environmental and economic well-being of the Mariposa region by, in part, reopening a recreational destination outside of the busy national park.

“Even though it’s right near Yosemite, this is a place that is, for the most part, untouched by people,” said Pickard, who grew up in the region and camped in the river canyon many times before the 2018 wildfire. “It’s fantastic back there.”

The west side, out of Hite Cove, is known statewide among nature photographers as a springtime hot spot for extravagant wildflower displays. The middle segment hews closely to the river, where hikers and anglers will find emerald pools and striking metamorphic rock formations.

“It truly is a magical place,” Pickard said.



Scenic trail camps are scattered throughout the river canyon.
Gregory Thomas / S.F. Chronicle

Rebuilding the trail has been a yearslong grind.

King coordinates a revolving cast of contract trail crews with American Conservation Experience, volunteer helpers and Forest Service rangers who, because of how remote the trail is, hike in all their tools and supplies on foot and sleep in tent camps by the river for up to two weeks at a time.

“That extraordinary dedication is what makes this partnership — and the trail’s revival — possible,” wrote Cori Hayth, Sierra National Forest District Recreation Manager, in an email to the Chronicle. “Bill’s infectious enthusiasm keeps his team motivated and engaged through the grueling work of trail maintenance.”

King, a self-described trail-repair fanatic, estimates he has personally made 60 trips to the heart of the trail to direct and carry out repairs. He keeps meticulous records of his group’s progress, which is gained an inch at a time. To date, crews have extracted 44,564 invasive shrubs, plants and weeds, sawed through 1,040 logs, pruned about 12,000 branches and removed 40 large rocks.

In some places, it’s like digging a tunnel through thickets of thorns; in others, it requires carving a bench-like footpath into the sides of steep slopes.

“There have been numerous days where we’ve come out and chainsawed through 40 or 50 trees in one day,” King said. “I like trail work, but you get to a point where you’re like, *oh, this is a lot*.”

On Tuesday morning, King led a crew on what he anticipates will be the final push: About 10 people hiked 9 miles in for a two-week stint to chew through the last mile of debris.



A group of volunteers with Mariposa Trails and a trail crew with American Conservation Experience gather before hiking into the river canyon.

Gregory Thomas / S.F. Chronicle

Though the landscape was filled with shoulder-high shrubs that shot up in the aftermath of the fire, sugar pine saplings, baby cedar trees and leafy black oaks had sprouted up along the trail as well. King would often pause to marvel at the growth of individual plants he has quietly observed over years, like a proud parent.

At one point, he stuck a trail flag handwritten with “Do Not Cut This” on a burgeoning black oak in the trail corridor. “The hope of what this (these trees) could be one day helps keep us going,” he said.

A key factor in awarding the grant to Mariposa Trails, Pickard said, was King’s clear dedication to the exhaustive work required to maintain such a remote trail, long-term.

When asked if he was concerned that a heavy winter forecasted ahead could wreak fresh havoc on the completed trail, King shrugged.

“We’ve done several rounds with Mother Nature at this point, so bring it on,” he said.

Getting There

Though both sides of the trail are open, the entire trail is not yet fully passable as workers restore the final middle segment. Check Mariposatrails.org for the latest information. The group cautions that the trail’s rugged character “will challenge even the most highly skilled outdoors person.”

“We’re not shy about saying, hey, if you want to come down here you need to know what you’re doing,” King said.

The group produces printed topographic maps available at the Mariposa County Visitor Center and other local businesses. A detailed description of the trail is available on Hiking Project.

Authorities warn about heat, rattlesnakes and other hazards: “Visitors should prepare for sections overgrown with brush and keep a look out for poison oak, while steep drops, river crossings, and eroded trail benches make navigation difficult for all but the most experienced trekkers,” according to Hayth of Sierra National Forest. Read more on the forest’s Stay Safe web page.



The South Fork Merced River Trail, a 21-mile thru-hike in Sierra National Forest with a small segment in Yosemite National Park, is being restored by the nonprofit Mariposa Trails, led by the group’s founder Bill King.
Gregory Thomas / S.F. Chronicle

Timing a thru-hike is critical.

King advises hikers to avoid the trail during peak summer months when temperatures in the river canyon can soar into triple digits. Also, the 21-mile route has two river crossings that can be impossible during the height of peak melt in spring. “A good rule-of-thumb for crossing is when the water level is 80 cubic per second or less as measured at the river gauge in Wawona,” according to the group. Check the National Park Service’s streamflow data page before you go.

The trail is at its most enjoyable during fall and drier winter periods when river flows are low and temperatures hover in the 50s and 60s, according to King.

Thru-hikers are recommended to begin their journeys at the Bishop Creek Trailhead on Wawona Road near Alder Creek in Yosemite National Park. Parking there is limited.There are bear boxes in a pullout but no trailhead sign or marker. Without a transit pickup on either side of the trail, hikers should consider parking a car at the Hite Cove terminus.

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Gregory Thomas

TRAVEL & OUTDOORS EDITOR

Gregory Thomas is the Chronicle's Editor of Travel and Outdoors, focusing on California activities and destinations, including Tahoe, Yosemite and the High Sierra. Before that, he served as Senior Editor at Outside Magazine in New Mexico where he edited news, enterprise stories and features in print and online. He’s worked at a tech-media startup, reported for major metro newspapers, written features for national magazines, and done his share of internships. He holds a master’s degree in journalism from UC Berkeley.

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